

# Shark Tank Dubai - Mal Plug-In Playbook

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Abdallah Abu Sheikh | Personal Investor Appearance

Prepared by Mal Marketing

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## Purpose

Abdallah is appearing on Shark Tank Dubai as a **personal investor**, not representing Mal. These scenarios equip him with natural, conversational moments to drip-feed awareness of what Mal is building — no hard sells, no promises. The goal is **indirect brand seeding**: positioning Mal in the minds of viewers, fellow Sharks, and entrepreneurs as the future of banking in the region.

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## Guiding Principles

- **Variety is everything.** Not every plug should name Mal. Some should just plant a frustration. Some should be a question. Some should be a personal story. The audience should never feel a pattern.
  - **Tie it to the entrepreneur's pain.** Only plug when it genuinely connects to a problem the founder just described.
  - **Earn the curiosity.** The best plug is the one that makes people Google Abdallah after the episode airs — not because he pitched, but because he said something that stuck.
  - **One per episode, max.** Restraint is what makes it powerful.
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## Delivery Style Guide

Each scenario uses a different approach. This is intentional.

| Style               | What it looks like | When to use                                        |
|---------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Question</b> |                    | When you want the audience to sit with the problem |

| Style                  | What it looks like                                                                     | When to use                                                              |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                        | Ask the entrepreneur something that exposes a gap Mal fills — never answer it yourself |                                                                          |
| <b>The Frustration</b> | Share a personal frustration as an investor/founder — no product mention at all        | When the moment is too early for a name drop                             |
| <b>The Aside</b>       | Briefly mention something you're working on, then immediately pivot back to the deal   | When a Shark or founder opens the door naturally                         |
| <b>The Credential</b>  | Reference a specific insight or stat that signals deep domain expertise                | When you want to be seen as the financial infrastructure guy             |
| <b>The Offer Hook</b>  | Tie your investment offer to a future resource you can personally connect them with    | When you're actually investing in the deal                               |
| <b>The Redirect</b>    | Respond to another Shark's comment by reframing the real problem                       | When another Shark says something about banking/finance you can build on |

## The 10 Scenarios

### Scenario 1: The Freelancer / Cross-Border Hustler

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur earning in USD or foreign currency mentions losing money on exchange rates, slow bank transfers, or SWIFT headaches.

**Style:** The Question

*"Can I ask you something — when you receive a payment from a client abroad, how much of that actually lands in your account? ... Right. So you're losing, what, 3-5% every single time? And you're okay with that? Because I'm not. That's one of the things that made me start my own company — I just couldn't accept that moving your own money should cost you that much."*

**Why it works:** He never says "Mal." He never describes the product. He asks a question every freelancer in the audience is now doing the math on, then drops that this frustration is what made him start his own company. The curious viewer Googles him. That's the whole play.

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## Scenario 2: The Struggling SME Seeking Capital

**Trigger:** A small business owner talks about being rejected by banks, needing working capital, or struggling with cash flow despite having real revenue and paying customers.

**Style: The Frustration + Redirect**

*"This is what breaks my heart about this region. You have a founder sitting here who sells every single day — real customers, real revenue — and a bank told them no because of a spreadsheet. The system is broken. Banks don't lend based on your business; they lend based on their own risk models that were built for a completely different world. That's actually why I left banking to build what I'm building now — but that's a conversation for another day. Right now, I want to talk about your margins..."*

**Why it works:** He validates the founder, calls out the broken system (which resonates with every SME owner watching), hints that he's building the alternative, then deliberately cuts himself off and pivots back to the deal. The "conversation for another day" line is the hook — it signals there's a story without telling it.

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## Scenario 3: The Young Founder Who Doesn't Know Their Numbers

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur can't articulate their margins, doesn't know where their money goes, or admits they're flying blind on finances. Another Shark might roast them for it.

**Style: The Credential**

*"I'm not going to roast you for that — honestly, I think the bigger question is why is it still so hard to know where your money is going in 2026? We all have AI that can write essays and generate images, but you still can't ask your bank 'where did my money go this month?' and get a straight answer. That's a design failure, not a you failure. My advice —*

*and this has nothing to do with whether I invest — find a tool that actually talks to all your accounts and gives you answers in plain language. They're coming. Trust me."*

**Why it works:** Zero product mention. Zero brand mention. But he just described Mal's PFM product on national television and told the audience "they're coming — trust me." The wink is subtle enough that it doesn't feel like a pitch, but anyone paying attention connects the dots when they see what his company does.

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## Scenario 4: The Car / Mobility / Automotive Pitch

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur pitches anything related to cars, mobility, car services, used car platforms, or automotive tech.

**Style: The Aside**

*"I love this space. I'll tell you one thing I've learned — the pain in car buying isn't finding the car. Everyone's solved discovery. The pain is what happens after: the financing. You go to a bank, they take a week, maybe they say no, mountains of paperwork. We're actually working on something in this exact space — fully digital, Sharia-compliant, offer in under 10 minutes from your phone. But look, that's my world — let's talk about yours. Walk me through your unit economics."*

**Why it works:** This is the only scenario where he describes the product in some detail — but he does it in one breath and immediately pivots back. It feels like a founder who can't help but geek out about his space for a second, not someone running a commercial. The specificity ("10 minutes from your phone") is what sticks.

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## Scenario 5: The Family-Focused or Education Business

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur pitches something related to families, children, education, school fees, edtech, or childcare. Or the conversation turns to the cost of raising kids in the UAE.

**Style: The Personal Story**

*"Did you know that a huge number of families in this country are paying school tuition on credit cards? Just to get through the term. And it's not because they can't afford it — it's because nobody's given them a better option that actually fits how they want to manage their money. That really stuck with me as a father. It's one of the reasons I do what I do outside of this show — I believe families here deserve financial tools that understand their life. Your kid's fees are due in September, your bank should already know that and help you get there. Anyway — I love what you're building. Let's talk numbers."*

**Why it works:** He leads with a real, relatable stat that every parent in the UAE recognizes — credit card tuition payments — which frames the problem as systemic, not a criticism of the country. He never says "Mal," never says "product," but every parent watching just felt seen. And when they look up who Abdallah is and what he's building, the connection is instant.

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## Scenario 6: The Health / Wellness / Medical Startup

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur pitches a health, wellness, fertility, or medical services platform. Or the conversation touches on the cost of healthcare in the UAE.

**Style: The Redirect (responding to another Shark)**

*"[After another Shark comments on the healthcare market size or cost] You know what nobody talks about though? The financing side. I know couples who've delayed starting a family — not because the treatment isn't available, but because paying for it feels impossible or the options available don't sit right with their values. That gap between 'the treatment exists' and 'I can actually afford it the right way' — that's a massive, massive gap. It's actually one of the things we're actively solving at my company — making sure the financial side disappears so people can focus on what actually matters. But that aside — tell me more about your patient acquisition costs."*

**Why it works:** He's responding to another Shark, not pitching. He names a real, emotional gap (couples delaying families), then connects it to "my company" in one line — enough for anyone to look him up — before pivoting right back to the deal. It lands because the personal weight of the topic does the selling, not the product description.

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## Scenario 7: The Scaling Business That's Outgrowing Its Tools

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur mentions operational chaos — juggling platforms for payroll, accounting, payments, compliance — or says they need to hire internationally and manage multiple currencies.

### Style: The Offer Hook

*"Here's what I'll say — I want to invest, and here's why: your product is strong, your team is strong, but your back office is going to kill you at scale. You're running payroll on one system, banking on another, compliance somewhere else, and none of them talk to each other. That's not a you problem — every SME in this region hits that wall. Part of the reason I want to be in this deal is that I'm personally very deep in the financial infrastructure space, and I think I can connect you to tools and systems that will collapse all of that into one place. So my offer is [X] for [Y]%, and I'm not just writing a cheque — I'm bringing you infrastructure."*

**Why it works:** This is the boldest play — he's tying his investment offer to his expertise in Mal's exact space without naming Mal. "I'm personally very deep in the financial infrastructure space" and "I can connect you to tools and systems" is the kind of line that makes the other Sharks ask questions off-camera. And when they do, that's when the real conversation about Mal happens — not on the show, but after it.

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## Scenario 8: The Expat Founder

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur mentions they moved to the UAE to start their business, or talks about the challenges of setting up as a newcomer — opening accounts, getting credit history, proving themselves to a bank that doesn't know them.

### Style: The Shared Experience

*"Can I ask — when you first moved here, how long did it take you to open a bank account? To get your first line of credit? ... Yeah. I hear this every single time. You leave a country where you had a credit history, relationships, a track record — and you land here and the system treats you like you don't exist. It's one of the biggest barriers to entrepreneurship in this region and nobody's really solved it yet. It's personal for me — I think if you're good*

*enough to get a visa and start a business here, you're good enough to be trusted financially from day one."*

**Why it works:** Half the entrepreneurs on Shark Tank Dubai are expats. Half the audience is too. This isn't a plug — it's a shared frustration that every newcomer to the UAE has lived through. He never mentions Mal or MalWelcome, but he's just described the exact problem it solves on national television. The "personal for me" line is the only breadcrumb needed — viewers will connect the dots when they look him up.

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## Scenario 9: The Portfolio Pattern (Mid-to-Late Season)

**Trigger:** This isn't tied to one pitch — it's a cumulative play. After Abdallah has invested in 2-3 companies on the show, a new entrepreneur comes in and mentions banking, payments, or operational challenges. This works best from episode 4-5 onwards.

### Style: The Investor Pattern

*"I'll be honest with you — every single company I've invested in on this show has hit the same wall. They outgrow their bank. Their payments are slow, their credit options are limited, their tools don't talk to each other. It's the one thing I keep seeing across every deal, every industry. That's actually why I'm so passionate about the financial infrastructure space — because it's not just your problem, it's everyone's problem. And the companies that fix it first are the ones that scale."*

**Why it works:** This is the Amira Sajwani play — it only works after he's built a track record on the show. He's not pitching a product; he's sharing a pattern he's observed as an investor. It positions him as the Shark who sees the financial infrastructure layer underneath every business. The other Sharks will ask him off-camera what he means, and that's where the real Mal conversation happens. By the end of the season, "financial infrastructure" becomes associated with Abdallah the same way "real estate" is associated with Amira.

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## Scenario 10: The E-commerce / D2C Founder

**Trigger:** An entrepreneur runs an online business — selling on their own site, through Amazon, Noon, or social commerce — and mentions pain around multi-currency payouts, marketplace settlement delays, or needing to pay suppliers before getting paid by the platform.

## Style: The Diagnosis

*"Let me guess your biggest headache — it's not marketing, it's not product. It's cash. Amazon pays you in 30 days, Noon pays you in 14, but your supplier in China wants payment upfront. So you're profitable on paper but you're constantly chasing cash to stay alive. Am I right? ... That timing gap kills more e-commerce businesses than bad products ever will. If you solve that — if someone gives you access to your own money faster, based on what you've actually sold — that changes everything for a business like yours."*

**Why it works:** He diagnoses the founder's problem before they even explain it — which instantly builds credibility and makes him look like the smartest person in the room on financial operations. He describes exactly what Mal's receivables financing and instant settlement solve, but frames it as advice ("if someone gives you access to your own money faster") rather than a pitch. The founder and the audience are left thinking: does he know someone who does this? Yes — himself.

## Quick Reference Card

| # | Trigger                            | Style                  | Mal Named?        | Product Seeded           | Key Line                                                   |
|---|------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Cross-border payments / FX loss    | The Question           | No                | Global Accounts          | "How much actually lands in your account?"                 |
| 2 | Can't get a bank loan              | Frustration + Redirect | No (hints)        | SME Lending              | "That's why I left banking to build what I'm building now" |
| 3 | Founder doesn't know their numbers | The Credential         | No                | PFM                      | "They're coming. Trust me."                                |
| 4 | Cars / automotive / mobility       | The Aside              | No (describes it) | Auto Financing           | "Offer in under 10 minutes from your phone"                |
| 5 | Family / education / school fees   | Personal Story         | No                | Retail Banking (Tuition) | "One of the reasons I do what I do outside of this show"   |



| #  | Trigger                                   | Style             | Mal Named?         | Product Seeded                | Key Line                                                                      |
|----|-------------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6  | Health / medical / fertility              | The Redirect      | Yes ("my company") | MalHealth                     | "One of the things we're actively solving at my company"                      |
| 7  | Scaling business / operational chaos      | The Offer Hook    | No                 | SME Banking (Full OS)         | "I'm bringing you infrastructure"                                             |
| 8  | Expatriate entrepreneur / new to UAE      | Shared Experience | No                 | MalWelcome                    | "Good enough to start a business here, good enough to be trusted financially" |
| 9  | Mid-to-late season / pattern across deals | Investor Pattern  | No                 | Mal Ecosystem                 | "Every company I've invested in has hit the same wall"                        |
| 10 | E-commerce / D2C / marketplace seller     | The Diagnosis     | No                 | SME Lending + Global Accounts | "That timing gap kills more e-commerce businesses than bad products"          |

## Bonus: Universal Closer

If any Shark, host, or entrepreneur asks "What is it that you're building?" or "Tell us about your company", Abdallah has one line:

*"We're building the financial backbone for this region — for people and for businesses. Sharia-compliant, AI-native, and designed for how people here actually live. That's all I'll say for now."*

Short. Mysterious. Moves on.

## Do's and Don'ts

**Do:** - Mix up delivery styles — never use the same approach twice in a season - Let the silence do the work after a strong line — don't over-explain - Pivot back to the deal immediately after a plug — show you're there to invest, not advertise - Use "I" and "me" more than "we" — it's a personal appearance - Save the best plug for the episode with the highest emotional stakes

**Don't:** - Say "at Mal we're building" more than once across the entire season - Name the product (MalHealth, MalTuition, etc.) on camera — those are internal names - Promise any entrepreneur access to Mal's services as part of a deal - Plug in back-to-back episodes — skip at least one episode between plugs - Use jargon (Murabaha, open finance framework, receivables financing) — keep it human - React if another Shark asks what you're building — smile, say "let's talk after," and move on